

EVALUATING THE DISTINCTIVE FEATURES OF THE OKI SOCIAL MASQUERADE OF OTUOBHI COMMUNITY

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Abstract

This paper examines the unique features of the Oki social masquerade of Otuobhi community of Anyama clan in the Ogbia Local Government Area of Bayelsa State. Though masquerades in African societies can have a spiritual, ritual and social role, social masquerades are non spiritual and are focused on entertainment, cultural education and unity. Literature available pays much attention to theatricality and aesthetics without sufficient literature covering the characteristic of social masquerades, especially Oki masquerade. The paper aims at assessing the distinctive features that distinguish the Oki masquerade against the ritualistic and other social masquerades in Nigeria with regards to its secular characteristics. The study used historical, sociological and emic approaches for data collection. The results show that, the Oki is a masquerade ceremony held on the 26th of December every year. The Oki masquerade dramatises how a predator fish endangering the river ecosystem, was trapped. It is characterised by the dramatisation of this story, secular costumes, music and dance, and openness of participation of men, women and children. The Oki masquerade does not require offerings, worship, or spiritual obligations, as opposed to ritualistic masquerades, and it focuses on the entertainment aspect, cultural promotion aspects, and functions of the masquerade to incorporate social unity. The research suggests that Oki masquerade should be marketed as a cultural tourist activity, the performance and equipment of the activity should be documented to be conserved and should be included in the educational and community activities to continue upholding Ogbia culture. Conclusively, Oki masquerade is an illustration of a social masquerade that breaks down the categorization of all masquerades as ritualistic, thus showing flexibility, inclusivity, and community importance in modern Ogbia community.

Introduction

The culture of a people is expressed in their way of life, their institutions, ideologies, artifacts, creative arts, dress code and more. These patterns of life evolved by the people are what distinguishes them from their neighbors. According to Zulu Sofola, these distinguishing cultural factors can be conceptualized as the “learned patterns of behavior, ideas, beliefs and artifacts, shared by a people and society, transmitted by them from one generation to the other” (qtd. in Solomon Ejeke, 64). Consequently, these transmitted patterns of life form the worldview of a people, their belief system, mode of worship, and interactions with the supernatural. Within this broader cultural framework, the culture of masquerade performance is common to Africans, but its perception and functions vary from one society to another. Although masquerade culture may appear similar across communities, its functions and usefulness often differ, because a masquerade is not what it says it is (cannot define itself), it is what the devotees consider it to be that it is. Therefore, a culture can classify a masquerade as

religious or secular depending on its perception and the functions it serves within the host society.

With the rise in modernity and the diminishing of ritualistic and religious adherence in many activities, the sacredness and ritual purity of many masquerade performances have gradually declined. This transformation has led to the emergence of social masquerades, which are defined by the loss of sacredness, ritual sanctity, and metaphysical essence (Samuel Ukala 164). Consequently, individuals pay more attention to entertainment and cultural expression particularly during social occasions like carnivals, marriages, burials, and holidays. This model is evident in social masquerades among the Ogbia people such as the Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuke and Oburumadu of Emeyal.

These masquerades are devoid of magic or ritualistic content. Their primary functions include entertainment, cultural promotion, propagation, preservation, and traditional artistic education (Baimane Ephraim Amange, 4, 7). In light of these distinct characteristics of different masquerades, this study's focus is to evaluate and articulate the distinctive features of the Oki social masquerade of Otuobhi community of Anyama clan in Ogbia Local Government Area of Bayelsa State, with particular focus on its performance structure, social features, and overall distinctive characteristics that set it apart from ritualistic masquerades and other social masquerades.

It is common knowledge that social masquerades are significant cultural manifestations in African cultures. Their primary functions are entertainment, educational and social. They have been examined by scholars in a variety of settings. Nevertheless, the vast majority of studies focus on theatricality, aesthetics, or dynamics of performance more than the particularities that characterize them. For example, Alex Asigbo reviewed carnival masquerades, their colorful costumes, and the avoidance of ritualistic objects, but did not consider the distinctive features that define them as social institutions (7). Ukala described numerous African social masquerades, among them the Buluba of the Makonde, Wara of the Bambara, Kwagh Hir of the Tiv, Owu and Ikaki of the Kalabari and Gelede of the Yoruba, focusing largely on theatrical and performative elements without detailed interrogation of their defining characteristics (162–164). Margaret Olugbemisola Areo and Abdulmalik Anatole Amali also identified entertainment and aesthetic purposes of social masquerades in Ile-Ife and among the Idoma, but did not specifically examine the features that differentiate social masquerades from ritualistic ones (67; 289).

Nevertheless, the central problem that gives rise to this study is the unanswered question of what the distinctive features of the Oki social masquerade are, especially when compared with other masquerades in the region and in Nigeria as a whole. There is also a total absence of scholarly material concerning the characteristic features of Oki masquerade and elements that distinguish it from ritual and other social masquerades. This scholarly gap has contributed to persistent misconceptions that classify all masquerades (the Oki social masquerade inclusive) as ritualistic or fetishistic, thereby restricting cultural understanding and weakening proper documentation of Ogbia masquerade traditions.

Accordingly, this study aims to evaluate and clearly articulate the distinctive features of the Oki social masquerade of Otuobhi community. The study is guided by the following questions:

- i. What features define the Oki masquerade as a social masquerade and,
- ii. How does these features distinguish it from ritualistic masquerades and other social masquerades in Nigeria.

Through the answers to the questions posed, the research contributes towards ethnographic knowledge and analytical insights into the area of Nigerian and African performance studies, especially in highlighting an aquatic-based, social masquerade.

Methodology

The study adopted the historical, sociological and emic models for data collection. The historical method was used to trace the origin and development of the Otuobhi people and their Oki masquerade culture. This involved examining historical documents, artifacts, and oral interviews regarding the community where the Oki masquerade is domiciled.

The sociological method involved direct interaction with members of the communities under study. Through interviews and informal discussions, Oki masquerade custodians and community members were engaged in order to obtain information on the origin, development, social functions, and communal meaning of the Oki masquerade in the Otuobhi community. This approach allowed the research to set the masquerade within its social background and in the interactions of everyday community life.

The emic approach consisted of participant observation and filming of the performances in Otuobhi community and other related social events during which the masquerade was performed. This participant observation was done over repeated performances within the fieldwork period to closely observe performance structure, audience participation, spatial organisation, among others. This insider perspective provided direct data for the analysis of performance style, structure, and communal meaning of the masquerade.

In addition, books, journals, magazines, and relevant online reports provided scholarly perspectives on masquerade studies. These sources were compared with field data to develop a contextual and analytical background for the research. It is conceded that the research is heavily reliant on oral testimony and binds the work to a more localized case study. These, however, are weaknesses with most ethnographic methods, and the rationale behind this approach rests on the premise of the detailed documentation and analysis of social masquerade tradition.

Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in performance theory, primarily informed by Richard Schechner (2003) and Victor Turner (1982), alongside secularisation theory, as discussed by Peter Berger (1967) and Bryan Wilson (1982). Performance theory describes cultural practices as performed structures, whereby societies enact their sense of identity, value, and social relations. This theory is useful in understanding Oki masquerade performance structure, aquatic and social space, audience participation, sequence of narrative, improvisations, and inclusive presentation. Oki masquerade is described as a play masquerade (ipo do lo) in which meaning is

derived from action and interaction, and not from ritual authority. The concept of secularization explains the way in which cultural practices are modified as a function of changes in society, specifically from the dominance of the sacred to other purposes such as social and artistic purposes. This concept is useful in understanding Oki masquerade in terms of the absence of ritual rights, the absence of restrictions and the sacred, and in terms of openness to all, regardless of whether one is a woman, child, and non-initiate.

These theories are appropriate because a social, theatrical, and communal performance aspect of the Oki masquerade is considered, as opposed to it being a ritual or a religious affair. Both theories combined explain a social performance structure that involves Oki masquerade (theory of performance), as well as its occurrence outside ritual performance (theory of secularization). These theories ensure that this research remains rooted in its background context, rather than within its defined analyses.

Literature Review

Masquerade Traditions in Nigeria

Masquerades are culturally deep in Nigeria, realizing a combination of spiritual, social, and artistic expressions. They mean different things to different ethnic groups: spirits of the dead, patrons of people, forest spirits, or water spirits. De-ritualized, they are masked performers or dancers on the streets. Ukala observes that masquerades are masked dancers that pay homage to the living at feasts, representing ancestors and supernatural beings with costumes, music, and dancing, masking their identity but not without cultural and spiritual significance (162). Masquerades have, therefore, two functions: religious masquerades worship, propitiate, and deify-usually in groves or shrines-while secular masquerades serve the purpose of entertainment but would show up at carnivals and socials. Religious masquerades therefore communicate with ancestors and deities, indicating the dual role played by masquerades as cultural and spiritual mediators in Nigerian society.

Some examples of masquerade traditions across ethnic groups in Nigeria are:

Yoruba (Egungun)

Among the Yoruba, masquerades are regarded as the spirits of departed forebears who appear to fulfill spiritual assignments (Ogundeji qtd. in Asigbo 5). In this context, the view on masquerade is that of sacred and spiritual function, and not secular. For instance, according to Oyin Ogunba, it is a tradition to consider that every year, the Egungun masquerade visits mankind to erase evil and bring peace and blessings (16). Further, Gilbert Fai emphasizes that Egungun demonstrates the continued guidance of ancestors (44). Akintoyo notes that Yoruba folklore regards masquerades as heavenly beings that sometimes instill fear, describing Egungun as a “skeleton made alive” (5). It is said that Yoruba masquerades connect the real world with the spiritual world, pay tribute to ancestors, and bring unity to the community.

Igbo (Mmanwu, Odo)

Igbo masquerades such as the Mmanwu and Odo can be considered super human and they end up holding a communion with the living as they are seen to be the incarnation of the spirit of ancestors (Odoja Asogwa, 40). They are observed in festivals, funerals, and farming cycles, which facilitate the wellbeing of the community and social bond (Ossie Onuora Enekwe 56).

Charles Oguamanam, et al., state that the Odo masquerade is a Godly messenger and it brings guidance, protection and blessings. Moreover, Odo masquerades serve social purposes, such as behavior control, marking the passage through the life, and fertility and prosperity (92-93).

Ibibio and Annang (Ekpo)

In the Ibibio and Annang communities, masquerades are viewed as the manifestations of the late spirits. Dominic Umoh asserts that “masquerades are spirits and not humans,” (102). Ebong Ukut explains that the Ekpo masquerade represents someone who has passed into the underworld (39). Looking at some of the functions of the Ekpo masquerades, it is explained that the Ekpo masquerades maintain social order, discipline, and morality while spiritually connecting the living and the dead (Edikan Ekanem, 1; Etop Akwang, 44).

Tiv (Kwaghir, Nyamtsuam)

The communities in central Nigeria, Tiv, view Kwaghir and Nyamtsuam as religious masquerades. Kwaghir is thought to be a representation of forefathers and fathers and the connection between the living and the dead. Dancers also wear costly dresses to present stories with moral and ethical teachings (Jonathan Mbachanga and Shadrach Ukuma 9-10).

Idoma, Izon, Kalabari, Nembe

Among the Idoma, Amali explains that masquerades function as communal avatars, linking the living with ancestors and deities (184). In Izon culture, masquerades are regarded as water spirits and ancestral manifestations. The Izon masquerade represents a sea spirit appearing during festivals (Augustin Emiemokumor 3). Corroborating this, Sunday Abraye & Tams Azobor note that Izon masks often resemble sea creatures, reflecting mammywater beliefs (89). In Nembe, Ogbari Ama-Ogbari explain that masquerades symbolize departed ancestors and appear during festivals, coronations, and burial ceremonies (382).

All these examples demonstrate the geographical and cultural diversity of the masquerade in Nigeria, but also emphasize the common purpose of their use as an intermediary between the spiritual and temporal world. In general, the Nigerian masquerades fulfill both religious and secular roles.

Types of Masquerades (Ritual versus Social Masquerade)

Ukala notes that the masquerades can be divided into ritual and social ones as each of them serves different purposes in Nigerian communities. The grouping is based on the distinctive features that set them apart from each other.

i. Ritualistic/Ritual Masquerades

According to Ukala, ritualistic masquerades have sacred functions, including the need to placate spirits, defile the territory, or to commemorate the death of chiefs and kings. Their performances are usually in small spaces such as shrines and groves and have few audiences especially during the night (162, 164). Okeke states that night masquerades are used in the removal of witches and spiritual order, and therefore strengthen their spiritual power in the community (118). This implies that the ritualistic/ ritual forms of masquerade serve sacred or religious purposes whenever being practiced. Oki masquerade does not fall within this category, as it lacks sacred functions, restricted audiences, or ritual obligations.

ii. Social/Entertainment Masquerades

However, Ukala notes that social masquerades are staged in the society as entertainment and educators. They lack any ritualistic characteristics, are only kept in order to be reused, and are available to the entire participants such as women, children, and non initiates (163). Similar differences are pointed out by Areo in Ile-Ife whereby social masquerade performances are open and inclusive (67). Asigbo validates the fact that social masquerades in Izon together with other societies have secular roles whose core role is concerned with cultural expression and entertainment (133). Oki masquerade is a prime example of a social masquerade, emphasizing entertainment, inclusivity, and communal participation.

iii. Day vs. Night Masquerades

This type of masquerades is distinguished in its own way. Tochukwu Okeke notes that day masquerades are done in open-air entertainment, but night masquerades are relatively ritualistic and serve the limited audiences (118). This category corresponds to the religious and social opposition of masquerade. But there can be ritualised masquerades which occur during the day depending on their functions which incorporate both sacred and entertainment functions and illustrate the interchangeability of ritual and social types and ends of masquerades. Oki masquerade aligns with the day/entertainment masquerade model, performed openly with full community engagement rather than limited sacred night audiences.

iv. Ritual Displacement and Transmutation from Sacred to Secular

According to Enekwe, the banning of ritualistic masquerades, the effect of foreign religions and modernization brought about the replacement of the rituals where sacred masquerades became the secular entertainment performances (22). This category includes the masquerades which were previously sacred and are now being celebrated as circular masquerades. Asigbo further notes that this change is also indicative of a larger cultural adjustment as masquerades change to ensure that they are socially relevant but the sacred powers they once possessed are no longer applicable (6). While Oki masquerade was borrowed from Nembe, it was introduced as a secular, play masquerade in Otuobhi and therefore embodies social adaptation rather than a sacred-to-secular transformation.

Features of Social Masquerade Performance

Nigeria has evolved characteristic attributes of its social masquerades that have sharply contrasted them with their ritualistic counterparts with their focus on entertainment, expression of culture as well as the wide dissemination of their activities to the community. These qualities help to learn how masquerades have been modified to suit contemporary social conditions and retain a certain link to the traditional aesthetics and performance traditions. The following are some of these aspects of the social masquerade:

i. Secular Mask Figure

According to Chidiebere Ekweariri, social masquerade masks are not regarded as gods or spirits, but as tools of disguising the identity, characterizing the identity, and dramatizing (83). Amange goes ahead to point out that the masks are commonly burned down after performances to avoid the causes of spiritual attachment and this further supports the secularity of the mask

(4). This conscious change highlights this transition between religious signage and artistic and dramatic functionality.

ii. Secular Appearance and Performance Arena

According to Ukala, social masquerades are practiced in the open in the secular and the public, without any limitations, to the rest of the community (163). This is unlike ritualistic masquerades which are only limited to shrines and sacred areas and in most cases only to initiates or few audiences (162). The transparent character of performance highlights the democratization of the masquerade culture, which is made available and inclusive.

iii. Secular Costume

Social masquerades have their costume which is decorative, colorful, and not contrived with any ritualistic or protective insignia and the new costume is focused on aesthetics and entertainment (Abdulmalik Adakole Amali, 189). According to Fiyinfoluwa Victor, the aspects of the performances like; Ibobo, Eyes token, and Adimu, which are traditionally associated with the power of the spirit, are consciously avoided in these performances to eliminate all spiritual and sacred affiliations. James Ndukaku Amankulor also validates the absence of ritual paraphernalia supporting secularism of social masquerades (152). These changes allow seeing the deliberate distance between social and spiritual masquerades, and remain visual and performative.

iv. De-ritualized Music and Dance

Music and dance are two aspects that cannot be talked about in a masquerade context. They are mainly geared towards entertainment, cultural advancement, rest and education in social masquerades. Being collaborative art forms, they increase the performance and involvement of the audience (Akpabot et al. qtd. in Amange 23). Social masquerades are not based on ritualistic performances but aesthetic enjoyment and educational demonstration. One might understand that social masquerades are codified in a systematic way as it is evident in all evidence that they are distinguished according to ritual forms. Their characteristics are; a secularized mask figure, purpose, and functional; a secularized costume; secularized music and dance; open audience participation, lack of spiritual power and accommodation of all sexes and participants during performances. Such characteristics do not exist in the ritualistic and religious masquerade performances.

It is very clear from all indications that, social masquerades are systematically codified to distinguish them from ritualistic forms. Their attributes include secularized mask figure, secularized purpose and function, secularized costume, music, and dance, open audience participation, lack of spiritual potency and the accommodation of all sexes and participants during performances. These distinguishing features are not present in ritualistic and sacred masquerade performances. Oki masquerade demonstrates these characteristics fully, with secular masks, costumes, music, dance, and open participation, reinforcing its clear placement within the social masquerade framework.

Analysis and Discussion

Oki Masquerade Performance Structure

Oki masquerade is a social masquerade of the Ogbia people specifically performed by the Otuobhi community of Anyama clan in Ogbia local government area of Bayelsa State. Oki masquerade, which is a pivotal masquerade performance in Otuobhi community, is an adaptation of a masquerade type in Nembe-Bassambiri. Oki masquerade, which is performed every 26th December, was brought to Otuobhi community by Mr. Donald Otunu in 1988. According to Betty Otunu and Victor Amaranya, core participants of Oki masquerade in its maiden stage, narrated that Oki masquerade is a play masquerade used for entertainment and leisure during festive seasons. This adaptation illustrates how communities actively reinterpret borrowed cultural forms for social and festive purposes.

According to Victor, the Oki masquerade performance tells a story of a wild fish called Oki that terrorizes the river, not allowing other smaller fishes to exist comfortably in the ecosystem. Oki, in its quest for dominance, succeeds in killing every fish in the river. Consequently, a fisherman noticed the violent act of Oki and decided to skillfully hunt Oki. The hunting of Oki was to enable other smaller fishes to live and develop in the river ecosystem. Accompanied with singing, drumming, dancing, and dramatic enactment, Oki was finally hunted and killed through a throw net. The enactment thereafter ended with singing and celebration for the defeat of Oki. According to Opuene Louise and Victor Amaranye, Oki masquerade is not a ritualistic masquerade. They both explained that Oki is a borrowed masquerade dance from Nembe and that it has no link with the worship of a deity in Otuobhi community. Here, the narrative emphasizes moral and ecological lessons rather than spiritual mediation, situating Oki clearly within social masquerade practices.

Social Features of the Oki Masquerade

Osain Ekinani, a prominent devotee of Oki masquerade dance, revealed that the masquerade dance was a youth and children festival celebration done in Otuobhi during festival seasons. However, due to the interest and entertainment satisfaction Oki performance generated, its grandeur and dexterity in performance, it was officially adopted as a communal masquerade performance every 26th of December. From the researcher's investigation, it was reported that a Christian revivalist called Rev. Justice Aggo visited the community in the early 2002 and wanted the masquerade dance abolished, but the community elders refused, arguing that the masquerade dance was not a fetish practice but a children's cultural party that keeps the Otuobhi community entertained during Christmas periods. This decision reflects the way the community navigates modern religious pressures while preserving secular, culturally relevant performance practices.

Notable among the elders who argued in favor of Oki masquerade was Chief Ase Wilberforce, the present paramount ruler of the community. He explained that, just as the Otuobhi community boys and girls travel to other communities in search of leisure and relaxation during Christmas periods, Oki masquerade is also used to entertain and attract population to Otuobhi community during the Christmas periods. Based on Oki's entertainment preoccupation and local tourism potentials, Oki masquerade was not destroyed like the masquerades of other communities within the period of Rev Justice Aggo's community crusades. The emphasis on leisure and tourism underscores Oki's function in reinforcing communal identity and social cohesion, distinguishing it from ritual masquerades.

In the preparatory stage of the Oki masquerade, boys and girls, men and women gather at the left end of the community in a creek called 'Obio. At Obio creek, a floating stage is constructed to ferry Oki and the other accompanying masquerades to the Otuobhi community. As shown in Plate 1, this preparatory scene highlights the performative and inclusive nature of Oki, where the entire community, not just initiates, participates. The creek itself becomes part of the performance space, emphasizing how geography and environment shape both the logistics and aesthetics of the masquerade.

Plate 1: Oki masquerade in an aquatic performance



The float carries the masquerade along with pilots and smaller accompanying boats. Despite being an aquatic performance, Oki does not honor river spirits or deities; no libations are offered, reflecting its strictly secular nature, described by devotees as “Ipo do lo” (play masquerade). Unlike other water masquerades such as the Ofuruma, Oki permits the participation of women and children. The image in Plate 1 makes this inclusivity evident, visually reinforcing Oki's community-centered, performative, and entertainment-oriented character.

Plate 2: Oki Masquerade been floated to the community for performance.



At this point, the masquerade is floated to the community for performance. As shown in Plate 2, the pilot attaches to another boat to help guide the float from Obio creek to the performance arena. The construction of the float, using light floating soft logs called “Oboya” in Ogbia, with additional soft plank woods on top, allows the masqueraders to stand securely. The raffia leaves tied around the float, visible in Plate 2, serve a decorative and spectacle function, distinguishing Oki as the pivotal masquerade from the smaller accompanying masquerades. While such raffia might suggest ritual symbolism in other contexts, in Oki they are strictly aesthetic, forming part of the masquerade's paraphernalia without any sacred connotation.



***Plate 3: The Procession
Boat of Oki***

Plate 3 represents the procession boat of Oki masquerade. As shown in Plate 3, the procession boat carries boys, girls, men, and women of the Otuobhi community who are active participants in the Oki masquerade dance. This visual composition emphasizes the inclusive and social nature of the masquerade, as participation cuts across age and gender. Unlike other masquerades such as Akpembe of Ewoi and Oburumadu of Emeyal 2 communities, which begin their procession from the community field or town hall, the Oki masquerade performance, as illustrated in Plate 3, begins from the river. This river-based procession, accompanied by participants as the masquerade moves toward the community playground, reinforces Oki's aquatic disposition and distinguishes its performance space and movement pattern from land-based ritual and social masquerades.



***Plate 4: The arrival of Oki
Masquerade at the
community water front.***

Plate 4 shows the arrival of the Oki masquerade at the community waterfront. As depicted in Plate 4, one spectacular aspect of the Oki performance is the careful observance of the water tide. The procession of the Oki masquerade follows the ebb of the river, a detail visually evident in Plate 4, where the float stage arrives smoothly at the waterfront. The significance of this practice is to allow the float stage to move freely without struggle and to avoid possible destruction of the float by a strong tide. This is because the ebb of the tide in Otuobhi community propels the movement of the river from Obio creek towards the Otuobhi community, thereby enhancing the smooth sailing of the masquerade float stage, as illustrated in Plate 4.

Plate 5: A dramatisation of a fisher man killing wild fishes



Plate 5 presents a dramatization of a fisherman killing wild fishes. As shown in Plate 5, the performance portrays a fisherman who kills all the wild fishes that do not allow other smaller fishes to survive in the river ecosystem. The drama begins with a circle dance by the participants, accompanied by singing and clapping, and continues until the arrival of the pivotal masquerade, Oki, as visually indicated in Plate 5. At the appearance of Oki, every other masquerade goes into hiding for fear of being killed by Oki. In the process of dancing round the arena, Oki kills all the smaller fishes in masquerade form and is finally trapped and killed through a drag net, a climactic action clearly illustrated in Plate 5. The death of Oki, as depicted in Plate 5, signals the climax and the end of the Oki masquerade festival for that year.

Plate 6: Men, women and children in performance.



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As shown in Plate 6, the active presence of men, women, and children within the performance space signifies the social nature of the Oki masquerade. This visual evidence in Plate 6 underscores the contrast between Oki and ritualistic masquerades where participation is restricted to initiates alone. Unlike ritualistic masquerades, the Oki social masquerade of the Otuobhi people, as illustrated in Plate 6, allows for the full participation of all members of the community; men, women, and children, thereby reinforcing its inclusive and non-ritual character.

Social Peculiarities of the Oki Social Masquerade

The Oki masquerade of the Otuobhi community of Ogbia LGA, Bayelsa state, is one particular example of social masquerade in Nigeria. The main discourse here is that, the Oki masquerade is uncharacteristically social, performative, and inclusive that makes it different in terms of structure, purpose, and cultural role as compared to ritualistic masquerades. The distinctive features are:

i. Performance and Geographical Orientation

Oki masquerade is held on a floating stage on Obio creek, and it is accompanied to the community ground followed by participants (men, women, and children). The float motion is aligned to the tidal ebb in order to create a comfortable navigation and charisma of the performance. This water environment is part of the identity of Oki, a mixture of the riverine dynamics and dramatic presentation of the narrative of a wild fish that frightens the river ecosystem. Conversely, ritual masquerades like the Igbo Mmanwu, the Yoruba Egungun and Ibibio Ekpo are held in supposed holy, earthly grounds like shrines or groves. Their performances are confined to the initiates or the chosen individuals but the emphasis is on mediation of spiritual matter and not aesthetic performance as obtained in the Oki masquerade performance. The concept of Oki, floating on the water, and made available to all members of the community is an indication of the conscious rejection and rejection of ritual feature, and the focus on entertainment, inclusiveness and cultural performance over the maintenance of religious power.

ii. Secular Orientation Obligation

Oki is entirely secular. It presupposes no offering, libations and worship and is specifically created to be a form of play masquerade (Ipo do lo) used to entertain and relax the people collectively during the seasons of festivals (Osain Ekinani). Its plot is a dramaticization of a catch of a predatory fish, which is combined with morality, environmental consciousness, and recreation. Ritualistic masquerades, in their turn, are religious and devoid of these entertaining features. The Egungun is considered an ancestral spirits whereas Ekpo imposes communal discipline and moral values. Participation in these masquerade performance is controlled and non-initiates, particularly women and children are often locked out to maintain a spiritual potency. The secular character of Oki masquerade, also disapproves the general misunderstanding that every masquerade is linked to rituals. Its absence of spiritual commitment and free involvement gives the culture of masquerade a new definition.

iii. Incursiveness and Community Inclusion.

The Oki masquerade of the Otuobhi community, is an example of social inclusiveness. As a

contrast to the ritualistic masquerades, where the taking part of people is limited, Oki gives all; men, women, and children the opportunity to participate fully in the procession, dramatization, and. The strategy builds communal unity, intergenerational interaction, and communal pleasure in cultural identity. In contrast, ritualistic masquerades are organized in a way to preserve hierarchies and spiritual secrets. It is only accessible to initiates who have undergone training and women and children are usually not allowed to attend and people must sit so that they follow the sacred procedures. The participative openness of Oki represents an intentional social purpose with emphasis on communal entertainment, and continuation of cultures over ritual exclusivity that is a characteristic deviation in ritualistic masquerades.

iv. Narrative Focus and Dramatic Structures.

The Oki masquerade performance is a well-planned dramatization. The story of a vicious fish and its capture is performed through singing, drumming, dancing, and dramatizing. The play has an obvious start, breaking point, and denouement, and focuses on theatricality and narration instead of preaching. On the contrary, the ritual masquerades are concerned with symbolic and sacred communication that intermediates the sphere of life and the world of spirits. Instead of the dramatized stories to be entertained, Mmanwu, Egungun and Ekpo are dramatization of ancient and cosmic values. These narrative framework and elements of the Oki masquerade, including drama, music and community involvement, highlight why it is such a social masquerade. It is a show made more to entertain and illustrate morals, not to be spiritual ritual, which sets it quite apart, as compared to ritualistic forms.

On the whole, all signs point to the fact that, the Oki masquerade of the Otuobhi community is a peculiar social performance masquerade which is not only secular, inclusive, but also community-based. It is acted on a floating stage on Obio creek and involves men, women, and children, which makes it easy to everyone to attend as compared to ritualistic masquerades that are practiced in limited sacred grounds. The story of the performance is that of a predatory fish and the process of its capture, which is sung, drummed, danced, dramatized, with its focus on entertainment, moral image rather than the spiritual or ritual ones. It has a secular costume, music and style of performance and there is no offering or worship. The masquerade creates a group of unity, intergenerational interaction and happiness, which shows its importance as a social institution. On the whole, the Oki masquerade dispatches the widely held view that all African masquerades are ritualistic in nature, demonstrating that social masquerades can flourish as participative, performative and culturally meaningful in the modern Ogbia society.

Recommendation

- i. The Oki masquerade can be vigorously marketed as major cultural event in the festal seasons by capitalizing on the special aquatic performance, involvement of participation, and amusing storylines in order to attract tourists and enhance tourism and economy in the area.
- ii. Scholars, cultural institutions, and community custodians should also provide detailed documentation of the performances, costumes, music, choreography, and narratives of Oki as a way of ensuring that the tradition is passed on to the future generation and also avoiding cultural erosion.
- iii. The Oki masquerade must be included in school programs, community outreach workshops and cultural festivals to teach young generation about Ogbia heritage, as well as

creating a link between the generations and instilling in the next generation its importance as social and cultural institution but not like a ritual.

Conclusion

This work has examined the Oki masquerade performed by the Otuobhi community as a social masquerade, with a clearly identified structure, spatial setup, and community participation. Through ethnographic analysis, this work has proved the non-ritual nature of the Oki masquerade, insisting instead on a purely narrative, recreational, and community-focused type of performance. Undoubtedly, the main point of this study is the contradiction it presents to the prevailing classification of masquerade, which tends to associate African masquerade performances with ritual, fetish, or ancestral worship. Indeed, the Oki proves that the traditional practices of masquerade can also have a deliberate social performance structure, marked consequently by a principle of open participation, narrative, and entertainment, as opposed to the practice of religious mediation. Its aquatic performance, the inclusion of men, women, and children, along with the lack of ritual commitments, place the practice firmly within a social masquerade.

Through this focus on the Oki masquerade as a play masquerade, this research extends the concept of masquerade beyond the aesthetic to analytical, such that the communities find ways to integrate the masquerade forms into contemporary social reality. Thus, the Oki masquerade plays a significant role in ensuring the malleability of the performance traditions on the continent of Africa.

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